Pilots declare emergency over fatigue reporting

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【要点】

・欧州コックピット協会が、パイロットの3分の1以上が十分な休息を取っていないという調査結果を基に、EU域内の疲労報告規則の強化を求めた。

・パイロットの約38%が、疲労報告に対する処罰や報復を恐れており、4人に1人が過度な疲労を報告せずに飛行を続けているという実態が明らかになった。

・現在のEU疲労報告規則は2016年から施行されているが、国や航空会社によって適用が一貫していないため、解釈の余地を減らすために改正が必要とされている。

・調査では、パイロットの4人に3人以上が過去4週間で航空機操縦中に微睡みを経験していることが判明した。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — The European Cockpit Associati

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SNEAK PEEK

— The European Cockpit Association called for tougher EU fatigue reporting requirements after a study showed that more than a third of pilots don’t get enough rest.

— Washington is proposing to extend its suspension of controversial port fees targeting Chinese shipping and shipbuilding until Jan. 2027.

— Lower Saxony premier Olaf Lies slammed Audi’s decision to announce a U.S. investment at a Trump campaign rally as Germany’s car industry sheds jobs at home.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

PILOT UNION CALLS FOR OVERHAUL OF EU FATIGUE REPORTING RULES: Ten years after they entered into force, the EU’s rules on reporting pilot fatigue are failing to ensure that pilots report when they are

excessively tired, according to the European Cockpit Association (ECA). The warning comes alongside the release of a survey commissioned by the pilots' union showing that almost 40 percent of respondents fear punishment for reporting fatigue.

Pilot fatigue is defined by the U.N.'s International Civil Aviation Organization as "a physiological state of reduced mental or physical performance capability … that can impair a crewmember's alertness and ability to safely operate an aircraft." Pilots are obliged to report this condition under the EU flight time limitations rules , which have been in force since 2016. As a general rule , crew members cannot exceed 100 hours of flight time in any 28 consecutive days.

Siesta in the sky: Despite the rules in place, a new ECA-commissioned study conducted by Baines Simmons, an aviation safety consultancy, found that more than three in four pilots surveyed experienced at least one microsleep — brief, unintentional periods of sleep — while operating an aircraft in the previous four weeks. In addition, more than one-third of the nearly 7,200 respondents reported that they usually or always lacked sufficient rest. One in four said they did not report excessive fatigue and continued flying anyway. Over 38 percent of those who provided written replies said they feared punishment or retaliation from management for submitting a fatigue report.

Current rules are applied inconsistently across countries and airlines, said Philip von Schöppenthau, ECA's deputy secretary-general. "They need to be overhauled and clarified in a number of areas to limit the interpretation room," he told Tommaso.

Who's lagging? The study ranked Ireland and Malta consistently among the worst-performing countries in areas including fatigue risk management, accessibility of fatigue reporting systems and trust in the reporting process. "Smaller countries are sometimes having difficulties in properly overseeing the airlines" operating under their supervision, von Schöppenthau said.

Low-cost carriers and companies leasing aircraft and crew to other airlines also ranked among the worst performers across most categories. "The airlines cannot get away with just simple tick-in-the-box rule compliance," von Schöppenthau said, noting that "air operators have to proactively manage their fatigue rates."

What's next? According to von Schöppenthau, "the European Aviation Safety Agency (EASA) is aware that fatigue is a big issue," and its upcoming report on the "best intervention strategy on aircrew fatigue" could recommend that the European Commission revise the rules. But such a move would have "very little support coming from the airlines," he warned, as carriers have always lobbied against additional requirements.

Regulator's reply: "EASA takes the findings of the ECA's 2026 Fatigue Survey seriously," said Janet Northcote, EASA's spokesperson, calling fatigue "a well-recognised aviation safety risk." EASA's recent research "provides further evidence to support improvements across the European aviation system," she added. Northcote stressed that "European flight time limitation rules provide a common safety baseline, but compliance with these limits alone is not sufficient."

See you in January: EASA's "best intervention strategy will consider the issues … to determine whether additional measures are needed, particularly around fatigue reporting and the effectiveness of fatigue risk management," she added, noting that its findings will feed into the next European Plan for Aviation Safety, expected by January.

MARITIME

US KEEPS CHINA SHIPPING FEES ON ICE: Washington is proposing to extend its suspension of Section 301 measures targeting China's maritime, logistics and shipbuilding sectors for another two months, through Jan. 9, 2027, giving the U.S. and China more time to negotiate before a controversial port-fee regime can snap back into force.

Back to last year: The measures stem from the U.S. investigation into China's dominance of maritime, logistics and shipbuilding, which led Washington to impose fees on Chinese operators and ships linked to Chinese shipbuilding. Those actions were suspended for one year from Nov. 2025, after a U.S.-China trade deal, while negotiations continued.

Now, more time: The U.S. Trade Representative says it wants to keep the suspension in place for a little longer. During that period, companies would not incur liability for the maritime transport fees or related duties covered by the measures.

Why Europe cares: The original U.S.-China fee fight created plenty of anxiety for European shipping companies, which found themselves exposed to both sides' retaliation. Some carriers reshuffled fleets to avoid U.S. charges on China-built ships, while others scrutinized board seats and shareholder structures after Beijing's countermeasures targeted U.S.-linked ownership. A further suspension therefore gives European operators some breathing room — but also prolongs uncertainty over whether the fee regime ultimately returns.

Next step: USTR is taking comments on the proposed extension through Oct. 30 before deciding whether to prolong the suspension.

SHIPOWNERS PUSH FOR BIGGER ETS PAYBACK: European Shipowners are urging the European Parliament and EU governments to put more shipping revenues from the EU Emissions Trading System back into maritime decarbonization, arguing that the sector contributes disproportionately to the scheme while getting too little support in return, in a statement out today and seen in advance by POLITICO.

Their main ask: ECSA, the shipowners' lobby, wants the proposed Sustainable Maritime Alternative Propulsion funding mechanism tripled from 110 million to 330 million allowances, saying the current pot covers only about one-third of what is needed to help close the cost gap between conventional fuels, and sustainable fuels and technologies.

What else: The group is also asking for support to cover a wider range of technologies, including energy efficiency projects, a dedicated shipping envelope within national ETS revenues, simpler MRV rules and a more predictable support system so companies know in advance how much of the green-fuel premium will be covered.

Offshore wrinkle: ECSA also backs the Commission's proposed changes for offshore vessels but wants one reporting and compliance system rather than different rules before and after 2031, warning that the split would add an unnecessary administrative burden.

CARS

AUDI'S TRUMP APPEARANCE BACKFIRES: Lower Saxony Minister-President Olaf Lies, who sits on Audi parent Volkswagen's supervisory board, has joined the backlash over Audi CEO Gernot Döllner's appearance alongside U.S. President Donald Trump at a campaign rally, saying "a campaign rally cannot be the right place to announce such an investment."

Boardroom warning: Lies stressed that no final decision has yet been taken on Audi's planned roughly $4 billion U.S. factory and said all conditions surrounding the investment must first be presented to Volkswagen's supervisory board. He said expanding in the U.S. could make strategic sense — but only if jobs and value creation in Germany are protected rather than shifted abroad.

Political spectacle: Lies said Döllner's appearance had caused "consternation" among employees worried about their jobs and beyond, adding that "a company executive has become part of a political spectacle." His intervention adds to criticism from German lawmakers and unions, who have attacked Audi for appearing to lend political support to Trump while Volkswagen is restructuring at home.

Germany first, too: Lies also said he expects the same determination Audi is showing in pursuing U.S. investment to be applied to finding "future prospects and solutions" for German sites currently under threat.

Audi issued a statement Monday in response. "An Audi delegation travelled to Georgia to move forward with discussions and negotiations regarding our planned production site. During these talks, we were asked to present our plans publicly together with the President of the United States," the statement says. "We accepted this invitation solely with Audi's best interests in mind."

TRUCKS

HAULERS PUSH FOR WEIGHTS AND DIMENSIONS DEAL: Eleven European road transport and mobility associations are urging the European Parliament and EU governments to strike a deal on the revised Weights and Dimensions Directive without further delay, according to a letter seen by POLITICO and sent to the file's main Parliament negotiator.

What they want: The groups say zero-emission trucks need enough extra weight allowance to carry the same payload as diesel vehicles, while countries should retain flexibility for cross-border high-capacity transport, including 44-ton operations and the European Modular System where national rules allow it.

PIT STOPS

Transport noise affects the entire population, but certain groups may face a disproportionate impact on their health due to greater susceptibility, higher exposure levels or a reduced capacity to cope with noise, according to a new report by the European Environment Agency.

EasyJet will begin offering high-speed internet on its flights through Starlink and will roll out the system across its fleet from the first half of 2027.

Port operator Hallands Hamnar signed an agreement giving the Swedish military access to the port of Halmstad's facilities from November 1, strengthening NATO's ability to move reinforcements and equipment across northern Europe.

Volkswagen has held talks with Czech defense group CSG about producing Tatra military trucks at its underused Hanover factory, Handelsblatt reports, citing people familiar with the discussions.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Greer issues warning to Europe over Airbus loan

The top U.S. trade official warns the loan “injects substantial uncertainty” into the future of transatlantic trade relations.
By Oliver Ward · Oct 27, 2026, 06:43 am Europe/Brussels CET

Quebec’s new separatist government wants a bigger role in EU ties
The province is staking a claim in areas like natural resources as new Premier Paul St-Pierre Plamondon envisages a longer-term push for independence.
By Jacob Parry · Oct 26, 2026, 06:55 pm Europe/Brussels CET

‘Disturbing and pathetic’: German politicians slam Audi CEO’s appearance at Trump rally
The German car manufacturer plans to open a factory in the U.S. state of Georgia.
By Sonja Rijnen · Oct 26, 2026, 01:02 pm Europe/Brussels CET

Europe vs. Elon: 5 ways the EU is trying to squeeze out Musk’s Starlink
Europe is working on several plans to break the dominance of the tech billionaire’s satellite communications service.
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